ASUS unleashes world's fastest GPU

In an effort to dominate the gaming hardware market, Asus has gone ahead and made the world's fastest GPU, by combining two ATI Radeon HD 5870 graphics cards into one. It will surely make a hole in your pocket, at $1,200. Named the Asus Ares, it is reportedly 32% faster than the Radeon HD 5970, and is available in a Limited Edition Metal Case and a ROG gaming mouse bundle. It apparently requires a 750W power supply to run. Aptly, Asus has tagged it as: Limited Edition, Unlimited Power.

The monster card will set you back by Rs. 1,00,000. We got our test piece just when this issue was going for print. Stay tuned for our review in the next issue.

Menawhile, Nvidia has released the DX 11 capable GTX460 that purportedly runs faster than the expensive GTX465 and offers you a 'bang for the buck', something quite uncharacteristic from Nvidia. It is apparently more energy efficient, consumes less power, runs cooler and sticks to a budget gamer's constraints. Benchmarks peg the $230 1GB GTX 460 above the $200 HD 5830, and just below the HD 5850. The GTX 460 however gives consumers the added advantage of Nvidia's 3D Vision, PhysX, and CUDA technologies. The sole advantage the HD 5830 presents over the GTX 460 is a slight price difference, and ATI Eyefinity. The GTX460 is presently available in India in two configurations:

The Nvidia GeForce GTX 460 768MB, is Priced at Rs.13,150 (approx), while the Nvidia GeForce GTX 460 1GB, is priced at Rs.15,100 (approx).

Meanwhile, the elder brother GTX 465 is priced for approximately Rs. 18,000 (approx) for the 1GB configuration.

AADHAR's API

The Indian government's plan to implement a unique identity code for each Indian citizen is finally bearing fruits. The Unique Identification Authority of India (UIDAI) has released an API specification for how identities would be authenticated with different agencies using a central database.

With a unique identity number assigned to each citizen, establishing and authenticating the identity of any individual will become much easier. Currently multiple identity documents are required for different government services. Each has a basic requirement needed to authenticate our identity. With a unique ID, and a means to authenticate that ID, this workflow would become much simpler and convenient.

The new unique identity system, named AADHAR, is projected to work by establishing one's identity using the AADHAR code, and any combination of biometric identification, such as fingerprint or retina scans. It appears that the creation of user ID could go paperless and validated/verified online.

When talking of a central database containing everyone's personal details, privacy concerns are sure to arise. The system developed with AADHAR is intended to prevent such abuse. The AADHAR API does not expose any way to access some one's personal details from the UID code; instead it merely allows authenticates the details you do provide against the central database to establish an ID. It will merely give a "Yes" or "No" response.

How this would work is that one would need to provide their AADHAR ID to the agency with which you need to establish your ID, this could be a bank where you are opening an account, or a government service you are registering for, such as a driving license. Using your UID and biometric data (fingerprint / retina scan etc.) captured on the device installed at such locations, the agency (bank, ration card office etc.) will be able to verify the details you provide.

Low energy Bluetooth 4.0 unveiled, expected to hit market by Q4 2010

While Bluetooth 3.0 has been alive and kicking for more than a year, very few devices have found use for it since its release in April 2009. This hasn't stopped the Bluetooth Special Interest Group (SIG) from enhancing the technology further, and now, they have announced the arrival of Bluetooth 4.0.

While developing the Bluetooth 4.0 Core Specification, SIG's primary focus areas were low power consumption using new 'low energy technology', apart from enhanced range and multi-vendor operability. They seem to have achieved what they set out to do, and claim that it will allow for several years' worth of battery life on standard coin-cells. This will allow for very small and low cost devices to incorporate Bluetooth as a budget friendly connectivity option. This hallmark 'low energy technology' feature of Bluetooth 4.0 promises to have "new [connectivity] applications in [the fields of] health care, fitness, security and home entertainment".

Complete specifications are available at Bluetooth.org. The following is the list of enhancements at a glance, mirroring the key advantages of the low energy technology:

- Ultra-low peak, average and idle mode power consumption
- Ability to run for years on standard coin-cell batteries
- Low cost
- Multi-vendor interoperability
- Enhanced range

Interoperability testing and qualification are proposed to take place at SIG's 37th testing event, UnPlugFest (UPF) 37, which is scheduled for 4-8th October, 2010, in Barcelona, Spain. The first devices featuring Bluetooth 4.0 are officially expected to make their presence felt by the end of the year.